Beauty Mark

By Craig Shafer

The Boy is an unnamed speaker somewhere between sixteen and almost adulthood.

THE BOY: (Pg 33-39) When I was getting ready, I went through all the things she could possibly say when I told her. No, seriously -- I did. Best case scenario included things like, "I already knew, but thanks for telling me," and "That explains why you're so fabulous." Worse case scenario include disowning, verbal abuse, beheading -- I'm kidding.

I mean, I thought maybe it would just fall somewhere in the middle, you know? Something like, "I really wanted grandkids," but I already had a response to that. "No you didn't. Who are you kidding? You hate kids."

So, I told her. I did. As my sixteenth birthday present to myself. .. "Mom, I'm gay." And umm, she just sat there. So, of course, I thought about all the great advice I'd gotten from whenyoufirstcomeouttoyourparents.com and they said that sometimes it takes a little while to process and that "gently reinforcing" the message can be very helpful. So I did. "Mom, I'm gay. Like, completely gay."

And I leaned forward like to hug her or whatever and she just pulled back, wrapping her arms around herself - like she might catch it or something. And I tried to make a joke, but she didn't laugh at all. And, umm, out of all the responses I'd gone through, this was the one that I hadn't thought about. Nothing. Just nothing. She looked at me for the longest time and then she just walked away.

INTRODUCTION

*Cassidy Creech was only 13 when he considered suicide. He feared a world where no one would want anything to do with him – even his church-going parents, whom he worried wouldn't accept him for being gay. This feeling was already a reality in class, where he was relentlessly bullied at his small-town school despite not having gone public with his sexuality.**

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Six out of 10 students reported feeling unsafe and ostracized in school because of their sexual orientation, according to a 2019 study from the Gay, Lesbian and Straight Education Network. And now with an unprecedented number of anti-LGBTQ policies introduced and implemented across our nation, the status of LGBTQ students is even more perilous.

No one should be afraid to go to school in America . . . But they are.

Beauty Mark by Craig Shafer

THE BOY: So, here's the thing, the secret they don't really tell you. Not a whole lot changes after you "come out." I mean, I don't know, maybe I was expecting like exploding rainbow starbursts to suddenly surround me or, a really hot guy on a unicorn to show up on my doorstep and take me out for pizza. But those things don't happen, and life just keeps being boring and doesn't change a whole lot at all.

I kept getting this telemarketer call on my phone, from, like, New York, and I know this is dumb, but I fantasized that it was Ellen -- you know, Ellen, from, like Ellen the show? inviting me to appear on her show, right? Because she brings kids on her show all the time that are special. And so, umm, I would go on the show and I would kiss Ellen dramatically on both cheeks and then announce, "Ellen, I'm gay." And she would smile, of course, and then ask me some questions. "Are you famous?" No. "Do you sing?" No. "Play any unique or unusual musical instruments?" Sorry, no. "Mathematical genius?" No. "Reaching here, but born with extra fingers on both hands?" Just ten.

So, moral of the story? No. Not special. Just gay. And just living in this hellhole out in the middle of nowhere without very many friends, no boyfriend in sight, not much of anything, you know?

Okay, but here's the thing. I came out to my mom, right? raging success, and then I came out at school, with the help of whenyoufirstcomeouttoeveryoneatschool.com of course, and, umm, it's not that I became, well, popular, but, mum, I guess I became, I dunno, "notorious?" Like, people were talking about me, and I thought, well, at least people are noticing me, right? It's better to be the "gay kid" then just nothing at all,

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

right? Right?

So, I decided to start a GSA at school -- that's a gay-straight alliance, if you don't know -- at school. Basically it's where gay kids and straight kids come together and they talk about gay stuff and straight stuff and, mum, well, they, I dunno, they "ally." I don't really know they're supposed to do, but it seemed like a good idea, okay? So, I wore a snappy bow tie to the first meeting, but, unfortunately, the turnout was somewhat limited. The turnout was two. Myself and the 70-year-old Home-Ec teacher who was forced to be the advisor because she wasn't advisor-ing any other clubs. And she umm, offered me home-baked cookies -- do I look like I need cookies? I need a boyfriend! and umm, she asked me if maybe it was "just a phase?"

And so I asked her if being a b**** was "just a phase" for her, and mum, the principal told me that that was probably pretty inappropriate and that Mrs. Nightengale-Marbletooth wasn't going to be the advisor for the GSA anymore. And I told him that the GSA only had one member anyway, and to just drop it.

Okay, but, anyway, here's the thing: being "notorious" means that people kind of start talking to you. They do. And, I mean, some of the time I wasn't sure if it was the good kind of talking, or if they were just talking to me because I was, like, the freak of the week or whatever, but I mean . . . I wanted to be noticed, I guess. I just didn't want to be nothing anymore, you know? I mean . . . I dunno.

So, umm, I get invited to this party, right? And, I mean, it isn't just a party, it's "A PARTY" the kind that somebody like me doesn't get invited to ever, right? But I'm not going to question fate, I mean, obviously, I was just meant to go, right? And it's a few of the football players -- the Varsity football players -- and they're telling me that they're totally cool with me and whatever and that I've got to come to the party, and so, of course, I go . . . right?

And so, I get there, and I'm thinking, this is how it is to ***be*** somebody, you know? This is how it is to be a cool kid. And kids are saying, "that's him, that's the gay kid," and

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

I'm thinking, whatever, right? It's okay. . . And so I'm drinking, just a little. . . okay, maybe more than a little, but whatever. . . and we're at this house - some rich kid's house, and a few of the guys, the bros, right? - they're all, you know, with me, and I'm thinking that this is awesome, right? And they're saying we're gonna go out to the field down from the house and I'm thinking this is really awesome, right? And so I go . . .

And it's dark and whatever and I'm stumbling around like a fool, but we're all walking together and I'm just trying to think straight -- well, not straight, but you know what I mean, but, really I'm just thinking that these guys do like me and that everything is going to be okay, and then. . . Well . . .

And then, one of them, out of nowhere, really, he hits me across the back of my head with a baseball bat and calls me a faggot.

And you know what's so weird? It felt like it took, I dunno, hours and hours to fall to the ground, you know? It musta only been a few seconds but it felt so long. And I was just thinking that it was some kind of dream or something, right? Like maybe a musical and we were all just pretending or that it was an episode of Ellen and she was gonna just pop up out of nowhere and tell everybody how special I was . . . but, umm. . . she didn't. Nobody did.

No. They were on top of me. And ripping at my clothes. And the blows just came one after another. And I think maybe I thought – wow - my body is kinda strong or maybe I'm dead. . . and umm. . . here's the thing -- I felt the blood -- my blood -- like in my eyes and my mouth, and one of the boys, he's just making this awful loud noise and at first I can't even figure out what it is, but I turn my head to look at him and then I get it. He's Woody the Woodpecker -- you know the laugh, right? And that's what he's doing. He's laughing at me.

And I hear glass breaking and that boy, Woody, he's right on top of me and he's holding a broken beer bottle and even before the glass touches my face- I know. Do

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

you know how that feels? Not the cutting, I mean. No. But the knowing. That hurts more. Knowing that it's going to happen and there's nothing you can do. You know the weirdest thing, though? That's not what I'm gonna remember, no. What I'm gonna remember is the grass. How soft and warm and nice the grass was up against my face while those boys were on top of me. That's what I'm gonna remember. Things are funny.

Okay, so, umm. . . I know what you're thinking. You think I don't know, but I know what you're thinking. You're thinking -- what did I think was going to happen? Going with those boys to that party? Well, I didn't think anything. I just wanted something to be okay, and, I'm sorry, but everybody says "we've come so far -- gay kids are fine at school now." Well, we haven't come so far here, now, have we? We haven't come very far at all.

I didn't die though. I am invincible. Not really, but if I was a superhomo I mean, a superhero that would be kind of an awesome thing to say, you know? I'm gonna be okay. I mean, my body's gonna be okay, I guess. This? *(He gestures to a large scar on his face)* Well, yeah, that's not gonna go away. But, umm, Marilyn Monroe, she had a mole, right? And umm, I have this. . . it's my trade-mark -- my beauty mark, right? It's unforgettable.

Anyway, my mom, she was there when I woke up. She, well, we talked. But umm. . . yeah, it doesn't matter. She does her best, you know?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Craig Shafer
Book: Fast Horse Plays, Round 6, Pg 33-39
ISBN: 978-1512244120
Publisher: Create Space Independent Publishing
Date (Month/Year): May 2015

AWARD HISTORY

2015 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier
2023 National Qualifier
2024 National Qualifier
NIETOC
CA State Qualifier
IL State Qualifier
IN State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier

**Intro story taken from an article entitled "Being Gay in High School Today" by Chris Azzopardi, Oct 11, 2017*
https://www.metroparent.com/education/school-issues/gay-high-school-today/

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY